

Formerly known as BALKAN STATES

SOUTHEAST EUROPE



SLOVENIA, CROATIA, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Yugoslavia, Macedonia, and Albania all lie in Southeast Europe. Ruled by

Turkey for nearly 500 years, all the countries, with the exception of Albania, were united as Yugoslavia in 1918. It was, however, an uneasy peace, and, in 1991, Yugoslavia split up as a result of rival ethnic and religious tensions. War broke out, lasting until 1995. Since then, fresh conflicts have occurred and the region is still struggling to recover from war.

Physical features

The western region of Southeast Europe is made up of limestone plateaus and steep mountain ranges separated by forested valleys. In the northwest of the region are the flat plains of the River Danube.

23°C
(73°F)



1°C
(34°F)

870 mm (34 in)

Regional climate

The inland plains and the coastal strip have a temperate continental climate, with hot summers and cold winters. Snow falls in the mountains in winter.



Mountains

Mixed forests of deciduous trees and conifers cover the mountain slopes that dominate the north of the region. The Dinaric Alps are barren limestone ranges, or karst, that rise to about 1,800 m (5,905 ft) along the Adriatic Sea coast.



Ethnic groups

Ethnic tensions and religious differences mainly between Christian Serbs and Croats and Muslim Bosnians in the region led to much bloodshed in the war of 1991–95. About 40 per cent of people belong to Eastern Orthodox Churches, and 30 per cent are Roman Catholics. The rest are Muslims, mostly living in Bosnia and Albania.

Bosnian Muslim
praying for her son
killed in the war.



Adriatic coast

The strip of land that runs down the Adriatic coast is narrow, and in places the mountains of the Dinaric Alps rise steeply from the sea. The landscape is mostly barren rock, with sparse vegetation. In winter, snow covers the cliffs, but summers are hot. The coast is prone to the *bora*, a strong, cold wind that blows off the land. More than 600 islands lie along the Croatian part of the coast.



Iron Gate

The Iron Gate is a 3-km (2-mile) long gorge on the River Danube that runs along the border between the Yugoslavian state of Serbia and Romania. The gate marks the point at which the river breaks through between the Carpathian and Balkan Mountains. In 1896, the Sif Canal was constructed to improve navigation, and, in 1972, a dam for hydroelectric power was completed.